

The

RISE

Report

FALL 2026 EDITION

START READING

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Introduction: Following the Data

The insurance market is shifting, creating new opportunities and complexities across commercial, benefits, and high-net-worth (HNW) lines.

COMMERCIAL

The market has softened for the first time since 2017, as premiums fell across all account sizes.

▼ 1.2%	▼ 2.7%	▼ 1.9%
OVERALL PREMIUMS	LARGE ACCOUNT-SIZE PREMIUMS	MEDIUM ACCOUNT-SIZE PREMIUMS

- Commercial property led the decline at -5.8%, as carrier capacity returned and some catastrophe risk moved back from E&S to traditional markets.
- Commercial auto is the exception: +5.8%, now its 59th consecutive quarter of increases, driven by claim severity and litigation risk.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Expect relief on property lines, but continued pressure on fleet and auto exposures.

Source: The Council of Insurance Agents & Brokers, Q1 2026 P&C Market Survey

EMPLOYEE BENEFITS

Pharmacy is now the dominant cost driver in employee benefits, but strategy and confidence haven't caught up.

- Pharmacy now exceeds 30% of total medical spend for some employers.
- 3 in 4 employers cite cost (specialty drugs, affordability, gene therapies) as their top pharmacy challenge.
- ~6 in 10 feel only neutral or unprepared to manage future cost trends.
- 43% aren't sure when their pharmacy strategy was last reviewed.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The gap is strategic, not informational; a disciplined, data-driven review is overdue.

Source: Assurex Global, Employee Benefits Market Check Survey, August 2026

HIGH-NET-WORTH FAMILIES & INDIVIDUALS

Capacity is improving, but the market is getting more sophisticated.

- Carriers are prioritizing risk quality, loss prevention, and accurate property/exposure data over price alone.
- Catastrophe exposure, rebuilding cost inflation, and rising liability severity are now core underwriting factors.
- Portfolio-level thinking (not policy-by-policy) is increasingly what separates strong placements from weak ones.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Insurability itself has become an asset families need to actively manage.

Source: Dowling & Partners, HNW Insurance Market Research Report

Insurance Market Insights

RELATIONSHIPS

Data Access is the Real Benefits Strategy

For employers looking to take greater control of healthcare costs, access to claims data can reveal what's driving spend, and where targeted action can make the greatest difference.

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INNOVATION

A New Market Dynamic is Reshaping the Risk Conversation

After years of rising costs and constrained capacity, shifting commercial insurance conditions are giving business leaders an opportunity to rethink not just what they pay for insurance, but how they use it to manage risk.

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STRATEGY

The High-Net-Worth Insurance Market Is Stabilizing. But the Market is Changing.

More insurance capacity is returning, but securing the right coverage still requires a strategic approach. As underwriting becomes more sophisticated, protecting significant assets means managing insurability alongside the broader wealth portfolio.

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EXCELLENCE

OSHA Resources: Be Ready Before an Inspector Arrives

When an OSHA inspector arrives, preparation matters. Two practical resources from CCIG's Safety team can help your organization know what to expect, what to do, and how to respond from the moment an inspection begins.

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Connection in Action

National Recognition, Powered by Our People

CCIG continues to earn recognition for both our growth and our people. We recently moved up five spots to #86 on Insurance Journal's Top 100 Independent Property/Casualty Agencies, while our Employee Benefits practice ranked #20 nationally among Business Insurance's Top 25 Benefits Brokers by Growth, following 18.2% revenue growth in 2025.

That momentum is backed by a strong culture. For the second consecutive year, CCIG was named one of Business Insurance's Best Places to Work in Insurance, with employees reporting 93% overall engagement and a 90% average across survey categories.

These recognitions reflect what continues to drive CCIG forward: talented people, strong relationships, and a commitment to helping clients better understand and manage risk.







Give for Good

Supporting Communities Across Colorado

Members of our CCIG Give for Good Team recently spent the day at the Denver Rescue Mission, rolling up their sleeves and serving lunch to more than 300 people.

We're proud of our team for showing up and supporting our community. A big thank you to the Denver Rescue Mission for the important work you do every day; we were grateful to be a small part of it.

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RELATIONSHIPS

Our relationships empower us to come together with creative, industry-leading solutions for our clients.

Data Access Is the Real Advantage in Benefits Strategy



Taylor Rogers
Executive Vice President
taylor.rogers@thinkccig.com

For employers looking for greater control over healthcare costs, self-funding is often positioned as the answer. But self-funding alone isn't a cost-containment strategy; the real advantage is access to data and what employers do with it.

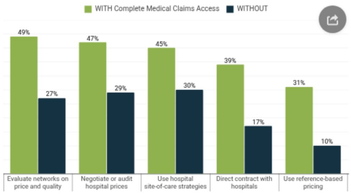
Recent findings from the National Alliance of Healthcare Purchaser Coalitions reinforce that point. Its 2026 Pulse of the Purchaser survey found that employers with complete access to medical claims data were more likely to take action across a range of hospital and high-cost claim strategies.

From Guesswork to Informed Decisions

Without meaningful claims and utilization data, benefits strategy can become a guessing game. Employers may know costs are rising, but not necessarily where the inefficiencies are, what's driving them, or which investments have the greatest potential to generate meaningful ROI.

National Alliance data shows how much visibility can drive action. Compared with employers without complete claims data, those with access were more likely to:

- Evaluate networks on price and quality: 49% vs. 27%
- Negotiate or audit hospital prices: 47% vs. 29%
- Use hospital site-of-care strategies: 45% vs. 30%
- Direct contract with hospitals: 39% vs. 17%
- Use reference-based pricing: 31% vs. 10%





The biggest differences appear in strategies that require employers to compare prices, assess providers, negotiate arrangements, or challenge performance. The bottom line is that it's difficult to manage what you can't see.

Self-Funding Opens the Door

This is where the conversation around self-funding can miss the bigger picture. With a fully insured plan, an employer transfers the financial risk for claims to an insurance carrier. Depending on the carrier, plan, employer size, and applicable requirements, access to detailed claims information can vary.

When an employer self-funds at least a portion of its health plan, it assumes responsibility for paying those claims. That structure can provide greater access to the information needed to understand how healthcare dollars are being spent. Self-funding can open the door, and data provides the prescription, but employers still have to take action.

Put Resources Where They Can Make a Difference

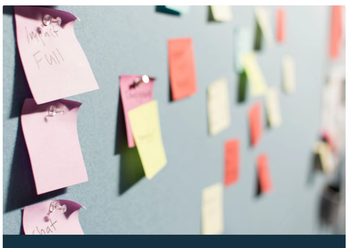
Changing a benefits program takes time, energy, and capital. Most employers can't pursue every cost-management strategy at once, so data helps them decide where to focus.

It might uncover opportunities to steer employees toward higher-value sites of care, address unusually high provider costs, evaluate network performance, or implement targeted programs for specific conditions. Instead of investing broadly and hoping something works, employers can prioritize strategies based on what their own population is experiencing.

Self-funding isn't a magic bullet, and data isn't, either. But when employers have visibility into their healthcare spend (and the expertise to act on what they find), they're in a much stronger position to make every healthcare dollar work harder.



Additional Resources & Information



Thought Leadership

The Renewal Is Decided Long Before It Shows Up

A health plan renewal is not a once-a-year financial event; it's the cumulative result of decisions made throughout the year. Employers that manage healthcare costs strategically use that time to identify emerging risks, act on cost drivers, and shape the outcome before the renewal ever arrives.

Learn More



Additional Resource

Benefits Support That Goes Beyond the Plan

Meet one of our team members behind CCIG's Benefits Support Center, providing year-round guidance that supports employees while taking everyday benefits questions off HR's plate.

Learn More

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CCIG

INNOVATION

Leading with data & insights, our team embraces change and pioneers new paths in insurance and risk management.

A New Market Dynamic Is Reshaping the Risk Conversation

After several years of challenging commercial insurance conditions, middle-market businesses are seeing more leverage at renewal. Our team reviewed The Council of Insurance Agents & Brokers' Commercial Property/Casualty Market Report for Q2 2026 (April 1–June 30) and developed key takeaways for leaders.

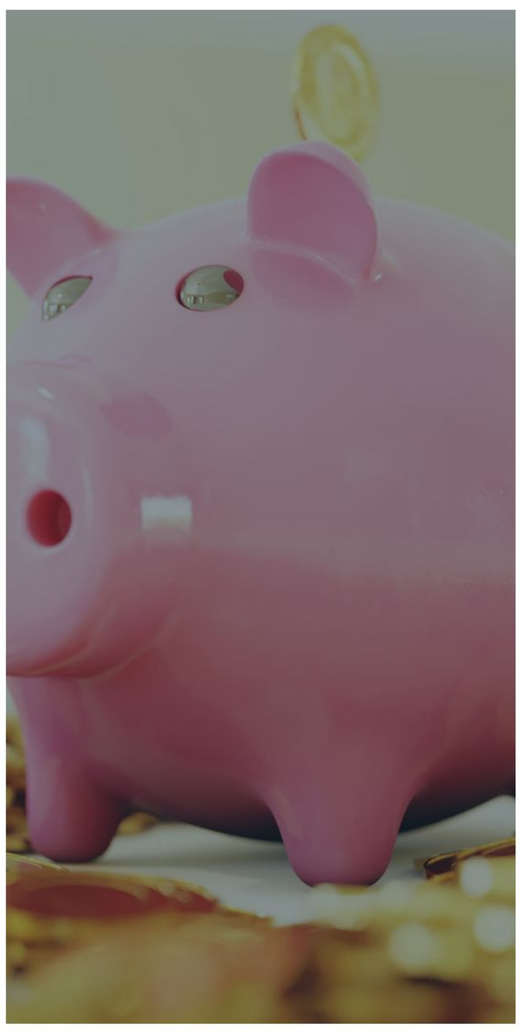
The commercial property and casualty market continued to soften in Q2 2026, with premiums decreasing across all account sizes for the second consecutive quarter. Medium-sized accounts saw average premiums decline 1.9%, while large accounts declined 3.7%. It was the first time in 34 quarters that every account-size category recorded a decrease.

For CEOs, CFOs, and other business leaders, the opportunity goes beyond lower premiums. Changing market conditions create a window to reconsider how insurance supports the organization's broader risk and financial strategy.

More Competition Can Create More Leverage

Ten commercial insurance lines recorded average premium decreases in Q2. Commercial property led the decline at 6.3%, while cyber and workers' compensation each declined 3.2%.

Property presents a particularly notable opportunity. 75% of survey respondents reported increased property capacity, creating greater competition among carriers. The report also noted opportunities for middle-market businesses to secure increased sublimits, while some insureds benefited from lower deductibles.



The Market Is Not Softening Everywhere

Commercial auto and umbrella remain important exceptions. Umbrella premiums increased an average of 5.3% in Q2, marking the 35th consecutive quarter of increases. Commercial auto premiums increased 4.5%.

Approximately 40% of respondents also reported a contraction in umbrella capacity. Claim severity and nuclear verdicts continue to influence the line, with commercial auto contributing to significant liability losses.

These divergent trends reinforce the importance of evaluating insurance as a portfolio rather than focusing on individual premiums. Savings in property or workers' compensation may coexist with continued pressure in areas that can produce significant balance-sheet volatility.

Revisit the Company's Risk Strategy

A changing market is an opportunity to reassess decisions made during more difficult insurance cycles.

- Does your deductible strategy still make sense for today's market?

Are liability limits appropriate given the company's current size and exposures?

- Should coverage that was reduced or restructured when capacity was constrained be reconsidered?

The goal is to find the right balance among risk transfer, risk retention, and total cost of risk. Leadership teams should also consider how emerging exposures are changing the organization's risk profile. As businesses adopt new technologies and operating models, insurance strategies need to evolve with them.

Key Takeaways for Middle-Market Leaders

As renewal approaches, executives should focus on these questions:

- Are improving market conditions creating opportunities to strengthen coverage, not just reduce costs?
- Do limits, deductibles, and retentions still align with the company's financial position and risk tolerance?
- Which exposures could still create significant volatility despite broader market improvement?
- Has the business changed faster than its insurance program?

The strongest insurance strategy isn't necessarily the one with the lowest premium. It's the one that uses capital efficiently while protecting the organization from risks it cannot afford to absorb.

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STRATEGY

Managing our clients' total cost of risk is a year-round commitment. Our strategy is where innovative ideas meet excellent execution.

The High-Net-Worth Insurance Market Is Stabilizing, But the Market is Changing.



Andy Orlando
Executive Vice President
Andy.Orlando@thinkccig.com

The high-net-worth (HNW) personal insurance market is improving, with stronger carrier results and more capacity entering the market. But for successful families, greater availability doesn't necessarily mean easier underwriting.

The latest Dowling HNW market analysis points to a more sophisticated market, with insurers placing greater emphasis on risk quality, mitigation, and portfolio construction.

HNW Insurance by the Numbers

- **$55 billion:** Approximate size of the U.S. HNW personal lines market
- **$15 billion:** Approximate premium written by specialist HNW insurers
- **27%:** Growth in specialist HNW E&S premium in 2025
- **83%:** Estimated share of California's HNW market written through E&S
- **50%+:** Share of specialist HNW premium written by market leader Chubb

Capacity Is Selectively Returning

Most major HNW insurers are now operating near or below breakeven combined ratios, bringing capacity back into the market, but insurers aren't simply loosening underwriting standards.

Instead, carriers are scrutinizing factors such as:

- Geographic and catastrophe exposure
- Construction quality and reconstruction costs
- Roof age and property condition
- Water detection and automatic shutoff systems
- Wildfire mitigation and defensible space
- Secondary-home occupancy
- Concentrations of property values

The result: Insurability itself has become an asset that affluent families need to actively manage.



E&S Is Becoming Part of the HNW Strategy

Excess and surplus (E&S) coverage is no longer a temporary solution for distressed properties. In catastrophe-exposed markets, it is becoming a permanent component of sophisticated HNW programs.

That requires looking beyond admitted versus non-admitted status. E&S policies may have different deductibles, exclusions, replacement-cost provisions, coinsurance requirements, and limits on additional living expenses.

For families with properties across California, Florida, Texas, New York, and other complex markets, the strongest solution may also involve multiple carriers rather than a single national insurance program.



The Takeaway

Personal insurance should increasingly be viewed as part of balance-sheet risk management, not just an annual renewal exercise.

HNW individuals and families should be asking:

- Are property limits keeping pace with reconstruction costs?
- Have new homes, vehicles, jewelry, collectibles, or other assets created coverage gaps?
- Are umbrella limits appropriate given increasing liability severity?
- Could additional loss-prevention measures improve carrier access?
- Is the current carrier structure still appropriate for the entire portfolio?

The HNW insurance market is becoming more sophisticated, and a comprehensive risk review can help ensure that as wealth and assets evolve, the insurance strategy evolves alongside.

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CCIG

EXCELLENCE

Our goal is to instill confidence that CCIG is your partner in navigating a complex insurance landscape with your best interests in mind.

OSHA Resources: Be Ready Before an Inspector Arrives

An OSHA inspection can happen without warning, and how your team responds from the moment an inspector arrives can significantly affect what follows. CCIG's Safety team developed two practical, comprehensive resources to help employers prepare, understand the inspection process, and respond with confidence.

Download the How to Survive an OSHA Inspection Guide for a deeper look at what triggers inspections, what to expect during the process, potential violations and penalties, and steps employers can take before, during, and after an inspection.

Pair it with the **OSHA Inspection Day Checklist**, a quick-reference tool designed to keep at the front desk or with site supervisors so your team knows exactly what to do when an inspector arrives.

How to Survive an OSHA Inspection Guide

Download the How to Survive an OSHA Inspection Guide for practical guidance on:

- What can trigger an OSHA inspection
- What to expect during the inspection process
- How to prepare before an inspection occurs
- What to do while an OSHA inspector is on site
- Potential OSHA violations and penalties
- Steps to take after an inspection

Download the OSHA Inspection Guide

OSHA Inspection Day Checklist

When an OSHA inspector arrives, your team needs to know what to do next.

The OSHA Inspection Day Checklist is a quick-reference resource designed to keep at the front desk, jobsite, or with supervisors and safety leaders. It provides clear steps to help your team respond consistently from the moment an inspector arrives.

Download the OSHA Inspection Day Checklist

Have questions about OSHA compliance or your organization's inspection readiness?

Contact CCIG to connect with our Safety team.



Strengthen Your OSHA Inspection Readiness

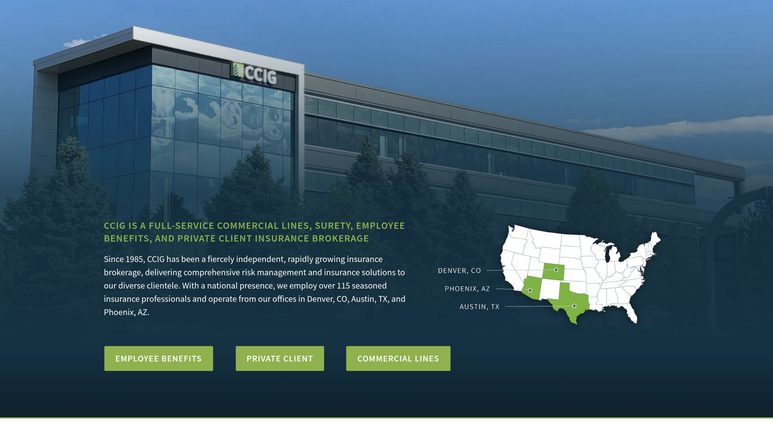
Preparing for an OSHA inspection is one part of a strong workplace safety and risk management program. Taking time now to establish responsibilities, review procedures, and prepare your team can help your organization respond more effectively when an inspection occurs.

CCIG's Safety team works with businesses to identify risks, strengthen safety practices, and prepare for regulatory inspections.

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CCIG IS A FULL-SERVICE COMMERCIAL LINES, SURETY, EMPLOYEE BENEFITS, AND PRIVATE CLIENT INSURANCE BROKERAGE

Since 1985, CCIG has been a fiercely independent, rapidly growing insurance brokerage, delivering comprehensive risk management and insurance solutions to our diverse clientele. With a national presence, we employ over 115 seasoned insurance professionals and operate from our offices in Denver, CO, Austin, TX, and Phoenix, AZ.

EMPLOYEE BENEFITS | PRIVATE CLIENT | COMMERCIAL LINES

Visibility & Influence in the Industry

CCIG's foundation rests on the belief that exceptional companies are built by exceptional people. Over our 40-year journey, we've attracted and retained industry leaders dedicated to delivering personalized, forward-thinking insurance solutions. Through strategic investments, we've expanded our reach to bring the resources and global market access of leading brokerages to the Texas and Colorado marketplaces.

The Independent Insurance Agents and Brokers of America has repeatedly honored CCIG as the "Best Practices" Insurance Broker. Insurance Journal ranked CCIG as a Top 100 Agency in 2025. We've been recognized as a Top Workplace by The Denver Post nine times since 2015.

Community Outreach

At CCIG, our Community Outreach Team, Give For Good, is dedicated to making a meaningful impact in our local communities. Through a variety of initiatives, we actively engage with community organizations, support local causes, and promote positive change. Our team collaborates with partners and volunteers to address pressing needs and foster community well-being, reflecting our commitment to not only providing exceptional service but also contributing to the betterment of the places we serve.

CCIG Leadership



Brook Mahoney
Founder & Chairman



Andrew Mahoney
President



Spencer Mahoney
Chief Partnership Officer



JB Richardson
Chief Executive Officer



Richelle McCullough
Employee Benefits Director



Bill Young
Risk Analytics Practice Leader



Gary Glader
Safety Practice Leader



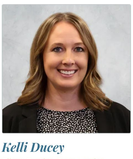
Chris Lujan
Director of Risk Management and Client Services ▪ Private Client Group



Beth Ficken
Client Service Team Leader, Select & HOA



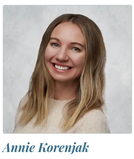
Jim Tolliver
Commercial Lines Sales Leader



Kelli Ducey
Client Service Team Leader, Construction



Julie Fitzgerald
Client Service Team Leader, Real Estate



Annie Korenjak
Director of Human Resources



Davis Snedeker
Director of Growth Marketing



Rob Acker
Director of Finance



Mike Welch
VP of Information Technology



Jana Cardinal
Director of Training

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Questions? We're always here to assist you in navigating your insurance journey.

Don't hesitate to reach out for more insights and personalized assistance with your insurance program.

CONTACT US

View More Insights at thinkCCIG.com

thinkCCIG.com

info@thinkccig.com | (303) 799-0110

155 Inverness Drive West
Englewood, CO 80112

Benefits Support That Goes Beyond the Plan



Adam Duval
Benefit Support Center Specialist • Employee Benefits Practice Area
Adam.Duval@thinkccig.com

At CCIG, our service doesn't stop once a benefits plan is in place. Our Benefits Support Center gives our clients' employees direct access to a real person who can help them navigate benefits questions and challenges throughout the year.



Our team can help employees with:

- Understanding coverage, costs, and eligibility
- Navigating claims and carrier communications
- Finding forms, portals, and benefits resources
- Exploring options to help manage out-of-pocket costs
- Understanding additional benefits and programs

For employers, that means less time spent troubleshooting individual benefits questions and greater confidence that employees have a knowledgeable resource ready to help.

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The Renewal Is Decided Long Before It Shows Up



Mike Burch
Executive Vice President, Partner • Sales Practice Area
mike.burch@thinkccig.com

I wish I loved the gym like I used to. I wish I loved eating clean every day. I wish I hit 10,000 steps each day with ease. The truth is, mostly I don't. But the handful of times I've actually done those things on purpose, it finally felt worth it. Health plans are the same way.

For many companies, the same thing happens every year: the CFO opens the renewal, sees a number that causes a slight blackout, and asks the only question that feels available: "How do we absorb this?"

The renewal isn't a surprise; it's a receipt for twelve months of decisions (and just as many non-decisions). It shows the large claimant who showed up in Q2, or the specialty drug that quietly became the plan's single biggest line item, or the surgeries that went to the most expensive facility in the network because nobody offered another option. None of that is in the renewal letter, but it's all in the numbers.

Claims Are a Warning

Most employers look at their claims once or twice per year, in the rearview mirror, when nothing can be changed. Groups that truly move their renewals watch claims all year long, flagging large claimants and emerging cost drivers the week they appear. A shock claim caught in month three is a strategy conversation, while the same claim found at renewal is just a bigger bill.

What Actually Moves the Number

When you're watching the plan in real time, you have levers. Used early, they add up:

- **Stop-loss strategy.** For a self-funded group, this is a major lever. Market the coverage and know your high-cost claimants before the carrier does.
- **High-cost claimant management.** Case management and care navigation on the handful of members driving most of the spend, including the million-dollar specialty and gene therapies that can wreck a renewal by themselves.
- **Bundled surgery and Centers of Excellence.** All-in negotiated pricing that strips out the markup buried in fee-for-service billing, typically with better outcomes too.
- **PBM strategy.** A transparent pass-through PBM, real specialty drug management, and step therapy where it belongs, because prescriptions add up and spread pricing is where it hides. This is another significant lever.
- **Early detection and chronic condition management.** Catching disease upstream, when it's manageable, instead of downstream, when it's catastrophic.

Every one of these levers has been sitting on the table for years. We all know what we're supposed to do. The reason they work isn't novelty; it's doing them deliberately all year, and only a handful of employers ever do. Put these in place now, build them into plan design before open enrollment, not bolted on at renewal, and you're already ahead of almost everyone.

The Actual Work



The strongest renewal strategy starts the day the plan year begins, with someone watching the claims, naming the risks out loud, and putting real strategies in motion while there's still time for them to work. The decisions that matter get locked in months out, not the week the number lands.

The groups that win their renewals aren't the ones who negotiate hardest at the end. They're the ones who paid attention the whole year.

If your renewal is heading somewhere untenable, the best time to act was a year ago. The second best time is today.

If you're interested in learning more about how CCIG can become an extension of your team, please reach out to me:
mike.burch@thinkccig.com

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